



Big Red Founder Challenge | Spring 2026

Challenge Brief

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About Trace.Space

Trace.Space launched Space Agent -- the first AI agent built from the ground up for systems engineers. We built it because we kept seeing the same thing across engineering organizations: smart, experienced people spending their days on work that had nothing to do with why they became engineers. Manual traceability audits. Keyword searches through requirement databases with tens of thousands of items. Hours spent linking requirements to tests, one by one, across documents.

Our customers include companies like Lucid Motors, Serve Robotics, and E-Space -- teams building electric vehicles, autonomous delivery robots, and satellite constellations where a broken trace link or missing requirement can mean failed certification, costly rework, or real safety risk.

Space Agent lives inside the platform, works directly with your engineering data model, and handles the tasks that eat engineers' time: coverage analysis, risk assessment, impact analysis, requirements and test creation, well-formedness checking, traceability monitoring, and trace suggestions -- each one 10 to 100x faster than doing it by hand. It is not a chatbot bolted onto an engineering tool. It operates inside your traceability chain, your coverage model, your requirement structure.

We serve teams stuck on legacy tools like IBM DOORS, Jama Connect, and Polarion -- and equally the teams cobbling things together across Excel, Jira, Confluence, and email. We are an early-stage startup based in San Francisco replacing both with an AI-native platform built for how modern engineering teams actually work.

Who We Are Trying to Reach

Our ideal customers are technical professionals and leaders at companies building complex, regulated products. The roles we care most about:

- Systems Engineers
- Senior Autonomy Engineers across aerospace, automotive, and robotics
- Engineering Managers, Directors, and Chief Engineers
- VPs of Engineering and other senior technical leaders
- CTOs, Heads of Engineering, and technical co-founders at deep tech hardware startups

These people work across aerospace and defense, autonomous vehicles, and robotics -- the same industries as our customers Lucid Motors, Serve Robotics, and E-Space. They are building safety-critical systems under real regulatory pressure, drowning in requirements documents, traceability gaps, and tooling that was never built for the scale they are operating at. Many hold or pursue INCOSE certifications -- they take their discipline seriously and expect the tools they use to meet that standard.

They are technical and skeptical. They have seen many software tools come and go. LinkedIn is their main professional channel but they are not LinkedIn people -- they show up there when they have to. Where they are genuinely candid is Reddit. The communities that matter most: r/systems_engineering (16,000+ members actively debating tools, methods, and whether MBSE is even working), r/aerospace, r/embedded,

r/MBSE, r/robotics, and r/AutonomousVehicles. These are not passive communities. Engineers here are openly frustrated with their current tools, which means there is a real conversation to insert Trace.Space into.

They respond to peer voices, honest takes, and content that treats them as experts. They do not respond to generic SaaS marketing.

The Challenge

How can Trace.Space break through to systems engineering leaders who have never heard of agentic requirements management, using a campaign with real viral potential?

Trace.Space has a product that solves a genuine pain point. What it does not yet have is broad awareness among the people who need it most. Your challenge is to design a viral marketing campaign for Space Agent that reaches our ICP and drives measurable engagement and coverage.

You are not being asked to build the product or redesign the brand. You are being asked to figure out how to make the right people notice us, talk about us, and share us, starting from zero paid media budget.

Constraints to Work Within

Budget

Assume zero paid media spend. The campaign must be executable with organic distribution only. If paid amplification is part of your strategy, it should be a small, targeted component, not the engine.

Team

Trace.Space has a small team. The campaign must be realistic for a lean startup to execute, not something that requires a full marketing department or agency relationship.

Brand and Audience

The ICP is technical and skeptical. Anything that feels like generic SaaS marketing, buzzword-heavy, or insufficiently informed about how systems engineers actually work will fall flat or actively damage trust. Your campaign must demonstrate genuine understanding of this audience.

Scope

This is not a rebrand, a product redesign, or a pivot. The campaign must work with what Trace.Space has today: its existing product, website, and public-facing presence.

What Success Looks Like

A winning campaign proposal will demonstrate a clear and credible path to:

- Meaningful LinkedIn engagement from the ICP, measured in impressions, comments, and shares from systems engineers and technical program managers, not just general audiences
- At least one realistic press or media coverage opportunity, whether through an industry publication, a podcast, a newsletter, or a broader outlet with a technical readership
- Community traction in the spaces where the ICP actually spends time, which you should identify as part of your research

You do not need to guarantee results. You need to convince us that the strategy is well-reasoned, the audience insight is real, and the execution is achievable.

What We Are Looking For in Your Presentation

Your deck should be no more than 7 slides. A light product demo is optional but welcome. Structure is up to you, but a strong submission will typically address:

- Your take on the ICP: who they are, where they are, and what makes them tick
- The core campaign concept and the insight behind it
- Channel strategy: where the campaign lives and why those channels make sense
- At least one concrete piece of campaign content: a draft post, a pitch angle, a content hook, or a hook for a Reddit thread. Show, do not just tell.
- How you would measure success in the first 30 days

Proposals may also include a video concept or creative content idea -- something with real potential to cut through in a space where legacy platform marketing has set an extremely low bar. To get started, explore our website, our LinkedIn presence, and how competitors in this space currently market themselves. The rest is up to you.

The best submissions will feel like something a smart, scrappy marketing team could actually ship next week.

Supporting Materials

In addition to this brief, participants are encouraged to explore the following:

- Trace.Space website: <https://trace.space>
- Space Agent launch post:
<https://www.trace.space/blog/space-agent-the-first-ai-agent-built-for-systems-engineers>
- Space Agent demo recording (private, not for sharing):
<https://media.sequel.io/bf6bfd39-948c-4d76-aa97-ba95a5212caf>
- LinkedIn profiles from the Trace.Space team: Janis, CEO (<https://www.linkedin.com/in/b2bsaas/>) -- Amanda, Sales (<https://www.linkedin.com/in/amandalucybagley/>) -- Karlis, CTO (<https://www.linkedin.com/in/cto/>)
- Reddit communities where our ICP lives: [r/systems_engineering](https://www.reddit.com/r/systems_engineering/), [r/aerospace](https://www.reddit.com/r/aerospace/), [r/embedded](https://www.reddit.com/r/embedded/), [r/MBSE](https://www.reddit.com/r/MBSE/), [r/robotics](https://www.reddit.com/r/robotics/), [r/AutonomousVehicles](https://www.reddit.com/r/AutonomousVehicles/)

We are happy to answer clarifying questions during the competition. If something is unclear about the ICP or product, ask. We would rather you get it right than guess.

A Note from the Judge

We are a startup. We do not have the brand equity of IBM or the marketing budget of Salesforce. What we have is a genuinely differentiated product and a target audience that is underserved by the tools available to them today.

We are looking for teams that take the time to actually understand systems engineers, not teams that apply a generic B2C viral playbook to a B2B audience. The winning team will show us something we have not thought of, grounded in real audience insight.

Good luck.